

Trading on his reputation, he went on to write more serious orchestral works, including the massive cantata *Belshazzar's Feast* (1931), his *First Symphony* (1935), and concertos for viola and violin. Having drifted away from the Sitwells, whose influence was on the wane, he embarked on a series of affairs, the most lasting of which was with Alice, Viscountess Wimborne, which began in 1934. He was exempted from military service during World War II so that he could provide music for propaganda films such as *The First of the Few*, and Laurence Olivier's *Henry V*, while living on Alice's estate in Northamptonshire.

Final movements

After the war, Walton found it difficult to return to composition, particularly after Alice died in 1948. But later that year, at a conference in Buenos Aires, he met, and soon married, Susana Gil Passo, an Argentinian woman.

By now, the composer's music was no longer fashionable, and although he was regarded highly enough to be commissioned to write the coronation march *Orb and Sceptre* for Elizabeth II, his output decreased significantly, especially after an operation for lung cancer in 1966. He and Susana moved permanently to the Mediterranean island of Ischia in 1956, where he died on their estate, *La Mortella*, in 1983.